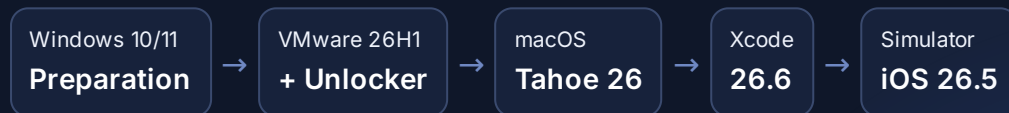


iPhone Simulator on Windows

How to run macOS Tahoe in VMware Workstation, install Xcode 26.6 and launch the iOS 26.5 Simulator — the newest iOS version you can get on a PC with an Intel processor.



What you will get and what to know

At the end you will have a macOS window on your Windows PC, and inside it Xcode with Apple's real iPhone Simulator — the same one iOS developers use on a Mac.

Why iOS 26.5 and not iOS 27

Xcode 27 (released September 14, 2026) runs only on Macs with Apple Silicon, and macOS 26 Tahoe is the last macOS version for Intel processors. A regular PC can only run the Intel version of macOS, so the ceiling is **macOS Tahoe 26 → Xcode 26.6 → iOS 26.5 Simulator**. This is the last combination available on x86 computers at all.

Option	macOS in the VM	Xcode	iOS Simulator	Stability in a VM
Plan A (main)	Tahoe 26.2 or later	26.6	26.5	Works, but support is limited
Plan B (fallback)	Sequoia 15.6 or later	26.3	26.2	More stable, fewer mouse issues

This guide follows Plan A. If Tahoe turns out to be unstable, the Troubleshooting section has a short Plan B — only three steps are different.

Apple's license

The macOS license agreement allows installing macOS only on Apple-branded computers. Running macOS in a virtual machine on a regular PC violates that agreement. Use this guide for personal evaluation and testing at your own risk; for commercial development, the legitimate options are a Mac or a cloud Mac (MacinCloud, MacStadium, AWS EC2 Mac).

Already using VirtualBox?

This guide uses VMware on purpose. VirtualBox has no Guest Additions for macOS guests, so there is no video acceleration, no shared clipboard and a fixed screen resolution, and recent macOS versions often boot-loop in it. You don't need to remove VirtualBox: VMware Workstation is free and installs alongside it, and your existing VirtualBox VMs stay as they are. Just avoid running VMs in both programs at the same time.

Limitations to know in advance

What	What it means in practice
Apple Account inside macOS	iCloud, the App Store and signing in to an Apple Account in the system itself won't work. Signing in to developer.apple.com in a browser does work — that's all you need to download Xcode.
Which apps can run	The Simulator runs only apps built from source for the Simulator (your Xcode project or a Simulator <code>.app</code> build). App Store apps and <code>.ipa</code> files for real iPhones can't run in it.
Speed	There is no GPU acceleration; graphics are drawn by the CPU. The macOS interface will lag and animations will stutter. It's enough for testing websites and debugging your own app.
Liquid Glass in Tahoe	The transparency and "glass" effects of the new design are not shown in a VM. This does not affect the Simulator.

About the illustrations

I can't take real screenshots on your computer, so every window in this guide is a recreated mockup with the same English labels and button layout as in VMware, Windows and macOS. The fields you need are outlined in red, and the numbers in circles show the order of actions. Colors and spacing may differ slightly in your version of the software.

What you need

Check this list before you start — most problems with this kind of setup come from the hardware or from Hyper-V being enabled.

Requirement	Minimum	Your setup / recommendation
Processor	Intel with AVX2 support (4th-gen Core, Haswell, or newer)	Intel is the best option for macOS in VMware
Virtualization	Intel VT-x enabled in BIOS/UEFI	Checked in step 1.1
Memory	16 GB in the PC	32 GB: give 16 GB to the VM, 16 GB stays with Windows
Disk	100 GB free space	150 GB on an SSD. On an HDD everything will be very slow
System	Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit	Administrator rights are required
Internet	Stable, $\approx$ 30 GB of downloads	macOS is downloaded from Apple's servers during installation
Apple Account	Free	Needed only to download Xcode from developer.apple.com

Software versions used in this guide

Software	Version	Where to get it
VMware Workstation Pro	26H1 (or 26H1u1)	Broadcom portal, free
Unlocker (BDisp)	3.1.4	github.com/BDisp/unlocker/releases
recoveryOS (DrDonk)	latest	github.com/DrDonk/recoveryOS/releases
QEMU (only qemu-img is needed)	latest	winget, package SoftwareFreedomConservancy.QEMU
macOS	Tahoe 26.x	Downloaded from Apple's servers during installation
Xcode	26.6, Universal build	developer.apple.com/download/all
Simulator	iOS 26.5	Downloaded from within Xcode

The whole process at a glance

STAGE 1 Prepare Windows Check VT-x, turn off Hyper-V and Memory integrity ≈ 15 min + reboot	STAGE 2 VMware Workstation Download from the Broadcom portal and install ≈ 15 min	STAGE 3 Unlocker Patch that adds macOS to the list of guest systems ≈ 5 min	STAGE 4 Recovery image Download Tahoe recoveryOS from Apple and convert it to VMDK ≈ 15 min
STAGE 5 Virtual machine Create the VM, attach the recovery disk ≈ 10 min	STAGE 6 Install macOS Format the disk, install over the internet, initial setup ≈ 60–90 min	STAGE 7 After installation VMware Tools, speed-ups, shared folders ≈ 15 min	STAGE 8 Xcode and Simulator Xcode 26.6, iOS 26.5 platform, launch an iPhone ≈ 45–60 min

STAGE 1

Prepare Windows

macOS works properly in VMware only when VMware controls the processor itself. If Hyper-V or Memory integrity is enabled in Windows, VMware switches to a slow compatibility mode, and macOS either lags badly or doesn't boot.

1.1 Check that virtualization is enabled

1. Press `Ctrl + Shift + Esc` to open Task Manager.
2. On the left, select **Performance**, then **CPU**.
3. In the lower right, find the **Virtualization** line. It should say **Enabled**.

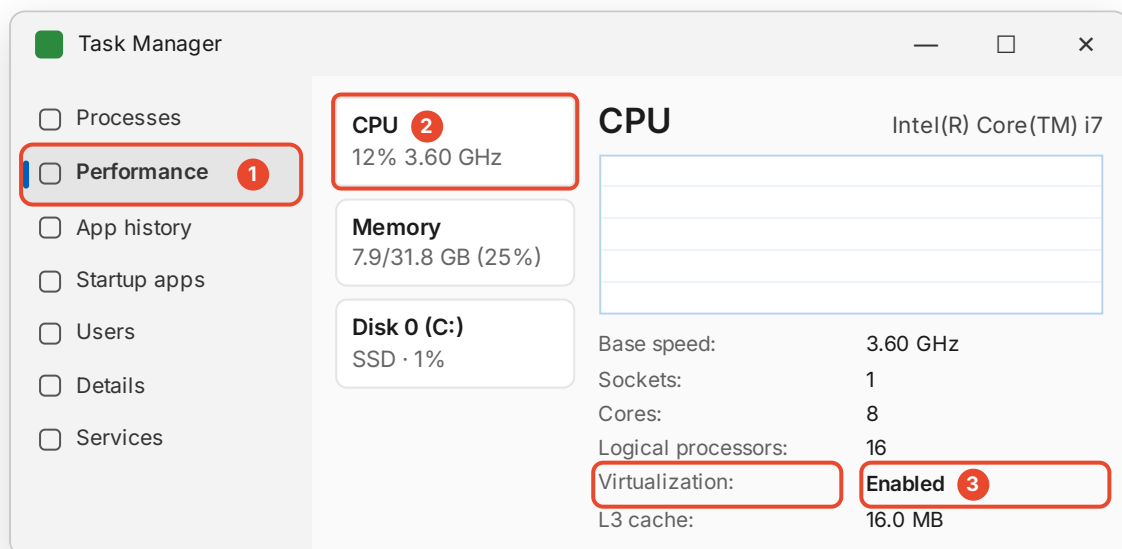


Fig. 1. Task Manager → Performance → CPU. The Virtualization line must show Enabled.

If it says Disabled

Restart the PC and enter BIOS/UEFI (usually `DeL`, `F2` or `F10` during boot). Find **Intel Virtualization Technology** (or **Intel VT-x, VMX**) — most often under **Advanced** → **CPU Configuration** — and set it to **Enabled**. Save the settings (`F10`).

1.2 Turn off Memory integrity

1. Open **Start** → search for **Windows Security**.
2. Go to **Device security** → **Core isolation** → **Core isolation details**.
3. Switch **Memory integrity** to **Off**. Windows will ask for a restart — you can do it after step 1.3.

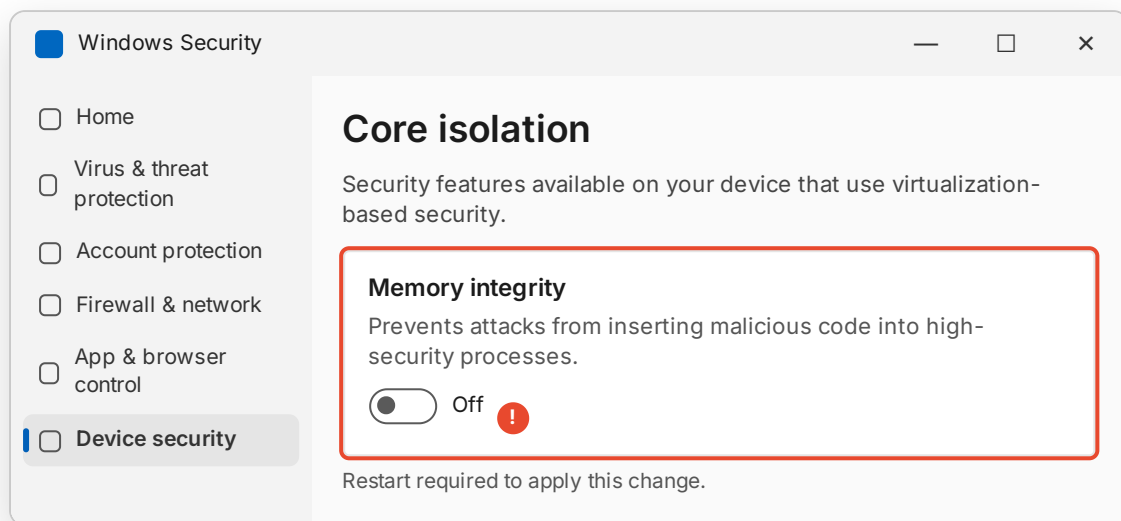


Fig. 2. Windows Security → Device security → Core isolation. Memory integrity set to Off.

1.3 Turn off Hyper-V and the Windows hypervisor

Click **Start**, type **PowerShell**, right-click it → **Run as administrator**. Run the commands one at a time:

```
Administrator: Windows PowerShell

PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Disable-Feature:Microsoft-Hyper-V-All /NoRestart
PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Disable-Feature:VirtualMachinePlatform /NoRestart
PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Disable-Feature:HypervisorPlatform /NoRestart
PS C:\Windows\system32> bcdedit /set hypervisorlaunchtype off

The operation completed successfully.
# If a feature isn't installed (for example, Windows Home has no Hyper-V),
# dism reports an error — that's fine, just move on to the next command.
```

Fig. 3. Commands that turn off Hyper-V, Virtual Machine Platform and the Windows hypervisor.

What stops working

After these commands, **WSL 2**, **Docker Desktop**, **Windows Sandbox** and Hyper-V-based Android emulators won't start. You can bring everything back at any time — the rollback commands are at the end of this guide.

1.4 Restart and check the result

After restarting, open Command Prompt and run `systeminfo`. At the very end, in the **Hyper-V Requirements** section, you should not see "A hypervisor has been detected". Instead there should be four lines ending in "Yes" — that means the Windows hypervisor is off and VMware can run in fast mode.

Extra check

Press **Win + R** and type `msinfo32`. The **Virtualization-based security** line should say **Not enabled**. If it says "Running", go back to step 1.2 — on some corporate laptops this feature is enforced by the administrator, and it has to be turned off through your IT department.

Install VMware Workstation Pro

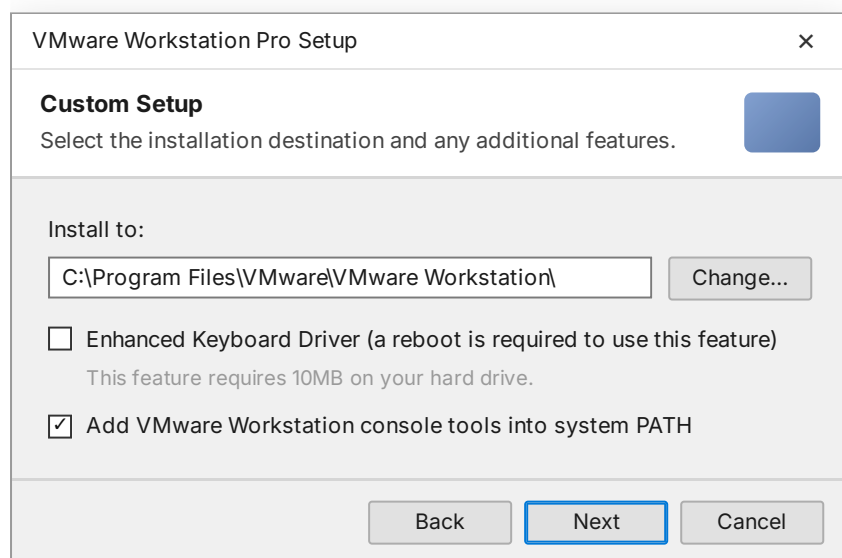
Since 2024, VMware Workstation Pro has been free for everyone — for both personal and commercial use. No license key is needed, but you can only download it after registering on the Broadcom portal.

2.1 Download the installer

1. Open **support.broadcom.com** and click **Register**. Fill in your profile with real details (name, address, country) — accounts with empty or made-up details can take a long time to be approved.
2. Confirm your email and sign in. For some countries Broadcom runs an export compliance check, which can take anywhere from a few hours to a few weeks. Until it passes, the downloads section won't be available.
3. In the upper right, select **Support Portal**, and in the division drop-down choose **VMware Cloud Foundation**.
4. On the left, click **My Downloads**, then the link **Free Software Downloads available HERE**.
5. Search for **Workstation** → **Show Results** → **VMware Workstation Pro**.
6. Choose the latest version, **26H1** (or **26H1u1**) for **Windows**, tick **I agree to the Terms and Conditions** and click the download icon.

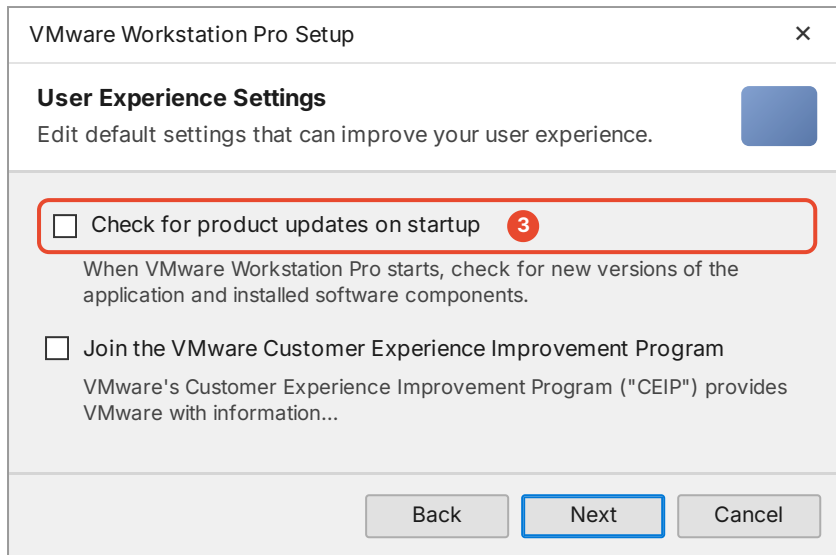
2.2 Install the program

Run the downloaded `VMware-workstation-full-...exe`. You can click **Next** on almost every screen, except for these two:



- 1 Keep the default install path — that's where Unlocker looks for VMware in Stage 3.
- 2 **Enhanced Keyboard Driver** is optional. It improves how system shortcuts work inside the VM, but requires a reboot.

Fig. 4. The Custom Setup screen of the VMware installer.



- 3 Untick update checks. Every VMware update wipes the Unlocker patch, and the macOS VM stops starting until you patch again. Update only deliberately.
- 4 You can leave the Customer Experience Improvement Program unticked — it doesn't affect anything.

Fig. 5. The User Experience Settings screen.

Finish with **Install** → **Finish**. If the installer asks for a restart, restart. You don't need to start VMware yet.

STAGE 3

Unlocker: adding macOS to VMware

Stock VMware for Windows has no "macOS" option in its list of systems, and booting macOS is blocked. Unlocker removes that block. The old Unlocker 3.0.x "finishes successfully" on VMware 26.x but actually patches nothing, so you need **BDisp 3.1.4**, where this is fixed.

3.1 Download Unlocker

1. Open github.com/BDisp/unlocker/releases and download `Unlocker-Windows-3.1.4.zip`.
2. Extract it to a permanent folder, for example `C:\Users\YourName\Downloads\unlocker-3.1.4`. Don't delete it after installing: it will hold a backup of the original VMware files and the script for re-patching.

3.2 Close VMware and run the patch

Make sure VMware Workstation is fully closed. Then open **Start** → type `cmd` → right-click → **Run as administrator**:

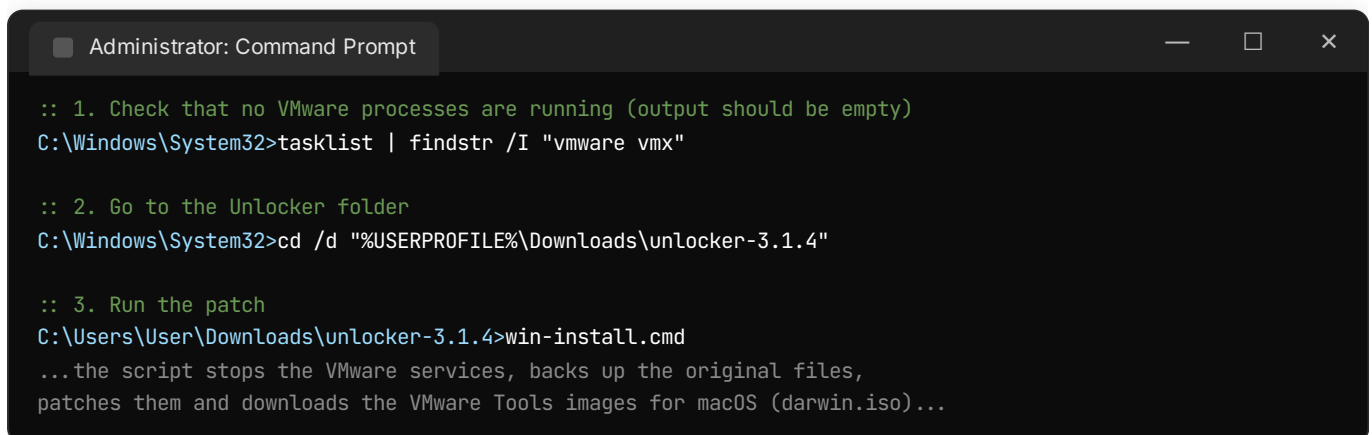


Fig. 6. Running Unlocker from an administrator Command Prompt.

SmartScreen or antivirus warnings

Unlocker modifies VMware's files, so Windows Defender sometimes treats it with suspicion. Download the archive only from the BDisp releases page on GitHub. If SmartScreen shows "Windows protected your PC", click **More info** → **Run anyway**.

3.3 Check that the patch was applied

- ☐ `darwin.iso` and `darwinPre15.iso` have appeared in `C:\Program Files\VMware\VMware Workstation\`.
- ☐ `vmware-vmx.exe` and `vmwarebase.dll` in the `x64\` subfolder have today's modified date.
- ☐ A `backup-windows\` folder with the original files has appeared in the Unlocker folder.
- ☐ When you create a VM, **Apple Mac OS X** appears in the list of guest systems (we'll check this in Stage 5).

After every VMware update

A Workstation update replaces the patched files with the originals. If the macOS VM stops starting after an update, close VMware and run `win-install.cmd` as administrator again.

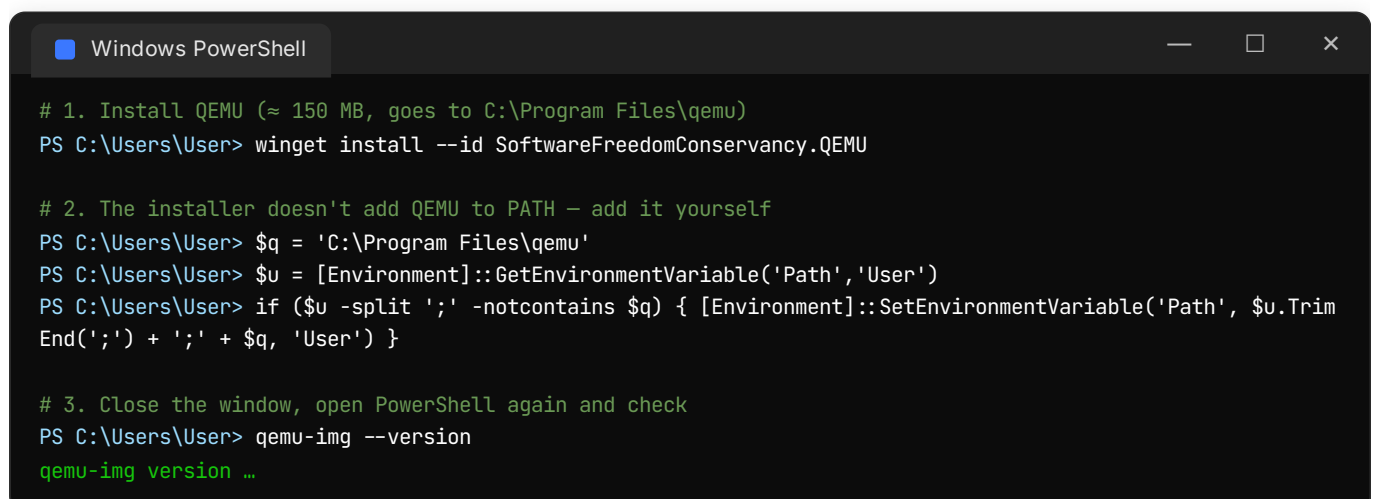
STAGE 4

Download the macOS recovery image

You can only get the full macOS installer on a Mac. But you don't need it: the recoveryOS utility downloads Apple's official recovery image (≈ 900 MB) from Apple's servers, and macOS installs from it over the internet. For VMware to attach this image as a disk, it has to be converted to VMDK with the `qemu-img` utility.

4.1 Install qemu-img

Open PowerShell (a normal one, not as administrator) and run:



```
Windows PowerShell

# 1. Install QEMU (≈ 150 MB, goes to C:\Program Files\qemu)
PS C:\Users\User> winget install --id SoftwareFreedomConservancy.QEMU

# 2. The installer doesn't add QEMU to PATH – add it yourself
PS C:\Users\User> $q = 'C:\Program Files\qemu'
PS C:\Users\User> $u = [Environment]::GetEnvironmentVariable('Path','User')
PS C:\Users\User> if ($u -split ';' -notcontains $q) { [Environment]::SetEnvironmentVariable('Path', $u.TrimEnd(';') + ';' + $q, 'User') }

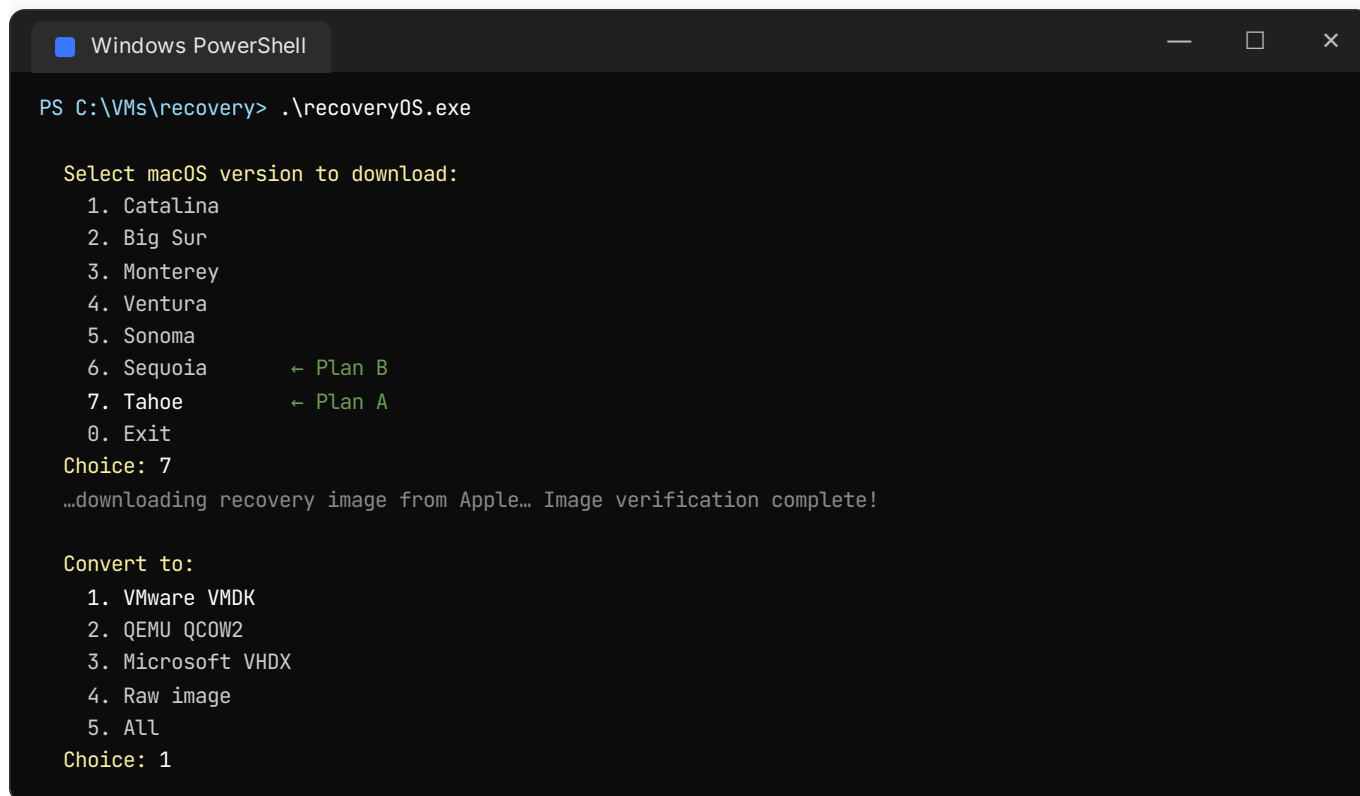
# 3. Close the window, open PowerShell again and check
PS C:\Users\User> qemu-img --version
qemu-img version ...
```

Fig. 7. Installing QEMU with winget and adding qemu-img to PATH.

4.2 Download the Tahoe image with recoveryOS

1. Open github.com/DrDonk/recoveryOS/releases, download the Windows archive and extract it, for example to `C:\VMs\recovery`. Inside you'll find `recoveryOS.exe`, `macrecovery.exe` and `boards.json`.
2. In PowerShell, go to that folder and run `.\recoveryOS.exe`.

3. In the menu, choose **7 — Tahoe**. Wait for the image to download and be verified.
4. When the utility asks for a format, choose **VMware VMDK**.



```
Windows PowerShell

PS C:\VMs\recovery> .\recoveryOS.exe

Select macOS version to download:
1. Catalina
2. Big Sur
3. Monterey
4. Ventura
5. Sonoma
6. Sequoia      ← Plan B
7. Tahoe        ← Plan A
0. Exit
Choice: 7
...downloading recovery image from Apple... Image verification complete!

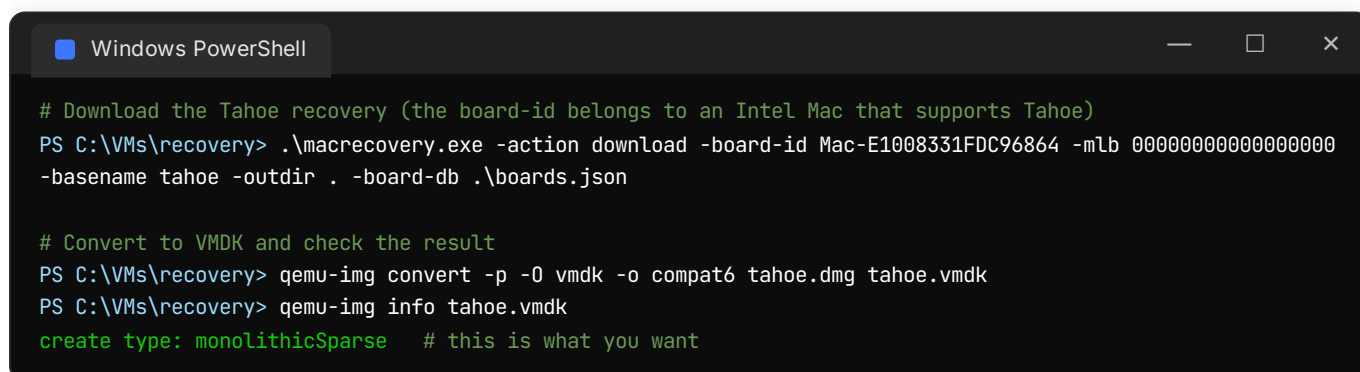
Convert to:
1. VMware VMDK
2. QEMU QCOW2
3. Microsoft VHDX
4. Raw image
5. All
Choice: 1
```

Fig. 8. The recoveryOS menu (approximate — wording may differ slightly in newer versions of the utility).

The folder will now contain `tahoe.dmg`, `tahoe.chunklist` and `tahoe.vmdk` (≈ 2.3 GB). The VM needs only `tahoe.vmdk`.

If the menu hangs or fails — the manual way

You can do the same with two commands. In PowerShell, in the recoveryOS folder:



```
Windows PowerShell

# Download the Tahoe recovery (the board-id belongs to an Intel Mac that supports Tahoe)
PS C:\VMs\recovery> .\macrecovery.exe -action download -board-id Mac-E1008331FDC96864 -mLb 000000000000000000000000
-basename tahoe -outdir . -board-db .\boards.json

# Convert to VMDK and check the result
PS C:\VMs\recovery> qemu-img convert -p -O vmdk -o compat6 tahoe.dmg tahoe.vmdk
PS C:\VMs\recovery> qemu-img info tahoe.vmdk
create type: monolithicSparse # this is what you want
```

Fig. 9. Manual download and conversion. Point `-board-db` to wherever `boards.json` is in the extracted archive.

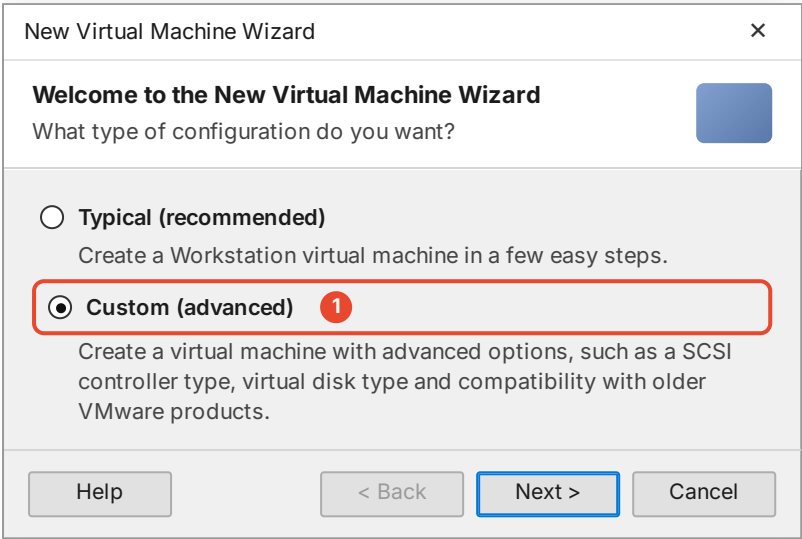
STAGE 5

Create the virtual machine

Start VMware Workstation and choose **File → New Virtual Machine...**. Below are the wizard screens

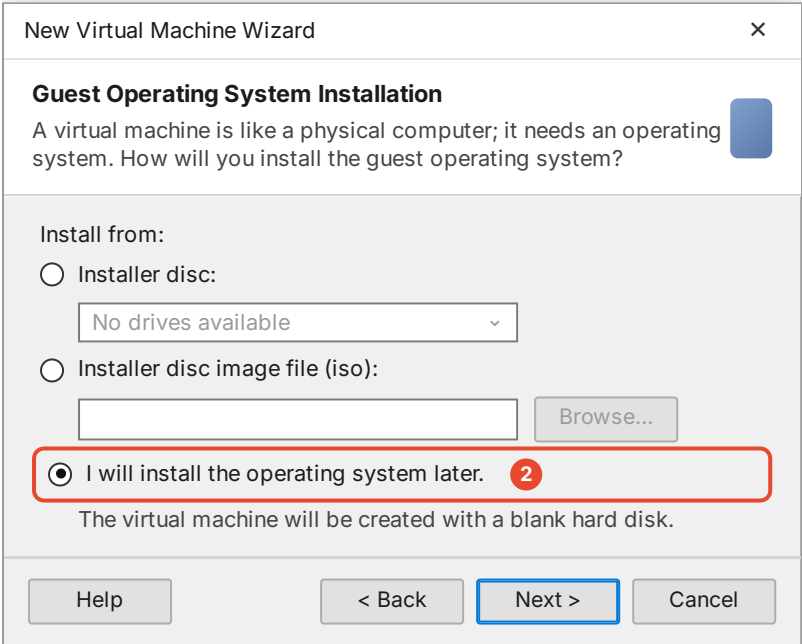
where you need to change something. On all other screens just click **Next**.

5.1 The New Virtual Machine Wizard



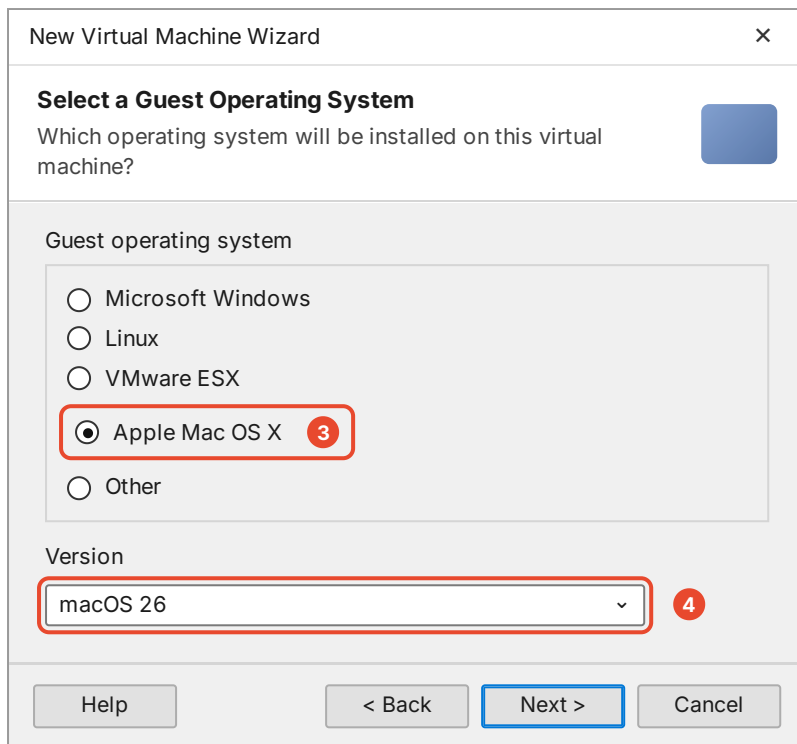
- 1 Choose **Custom (advanced)** — it's the only way to set the SATA disk type and the number of cores.
- On the next screen, **Hardware Compatibility**, keep the default (the newest version).

Fig. 10. Choosing the configuration type.



- 2 I will install the operating system later — we'll attach the recovery image as a second hard disk, not as an ISO.

Fig. 11. How the system will be installed.



New Virtual Machine Wizard

Select a Guest Operating System

Which operating system will be installed on this virtual machine?

Guest operating system

- ☐ Microsoft Windows
- ☐ Linux
- ☐ VMware ESX
- ☒ Apple Mac OS X 3
- ☐ Other

Version

macOS 26 4

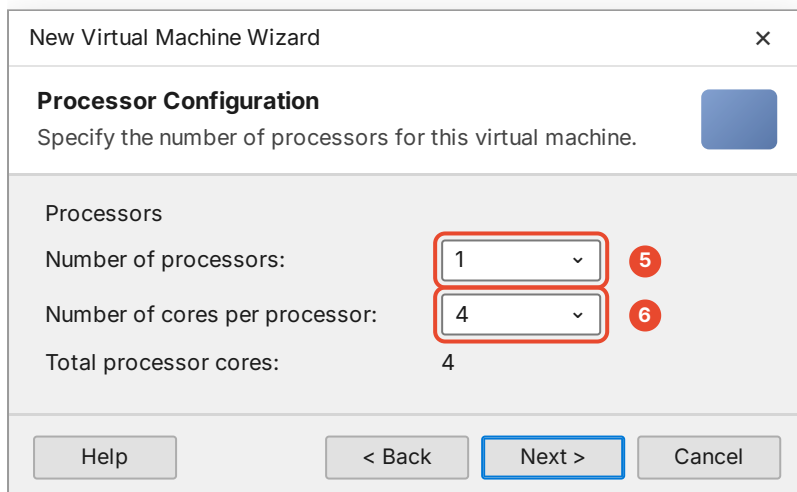
Help < Back Next > Cancel

3 Apple Mac OS X (in some builds, **Apple macOS**) appears only after Unlocker. If it's missing, go back to Stage 3.

4 The version must match the image: **macOS 26** for Tahoe (**macOS 15** for Plan B). A mismatch is a common reason the VM won't boot.

Fig. 12. Choosing the guest system and version.

On the **Name the Virtual Machine** screen, enter the name `macOS Tahoe` and a folder, for example `C:\VMs\macOS Tahoe`. Next come the processor and memory.



New Virtual Machine Wizard

Processor Configuration

Specify the number of processors for this virtual machine.

Processors

Number of processors: 1 5

Number of cores per processor: 4 6

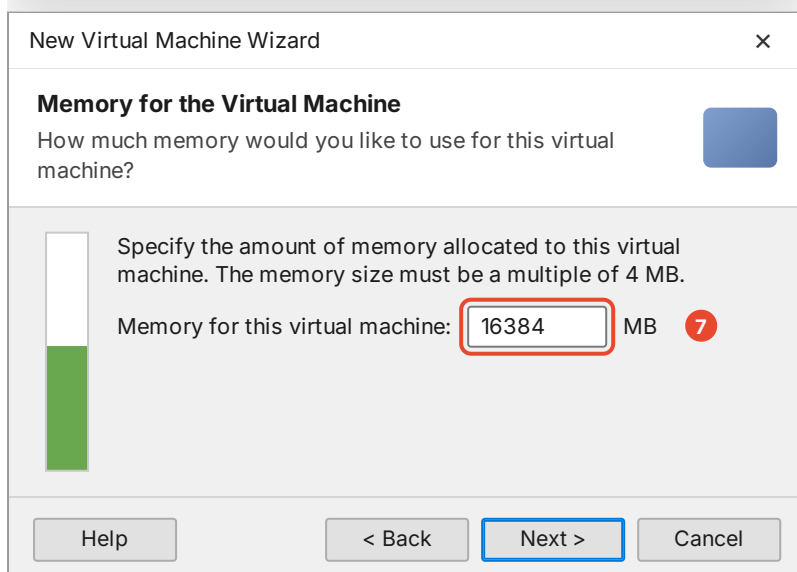
Total processor cores: 4

Help < Back Next > Cancel

5 Processors: 1. macOS expects a single processor socket; a multi-"processor" setup often causes an error.

6 Cores: 4. If your Intel CPU has 8 or more physical cores, you can use 8. Use only even values (2, 4, 8) — odd ones, such as 3, don't boot.

Fig. 13. Processor configuration.



New Virtual Machine Wizard

Memory for the Virtual Machine

How much memory would you like to use for this virtual machine?

Specify the amount of memory allocated to this virtual machine. The memory size must be a multiple of 4 MB.

Memory for this virtual machine: 16384 MB 7

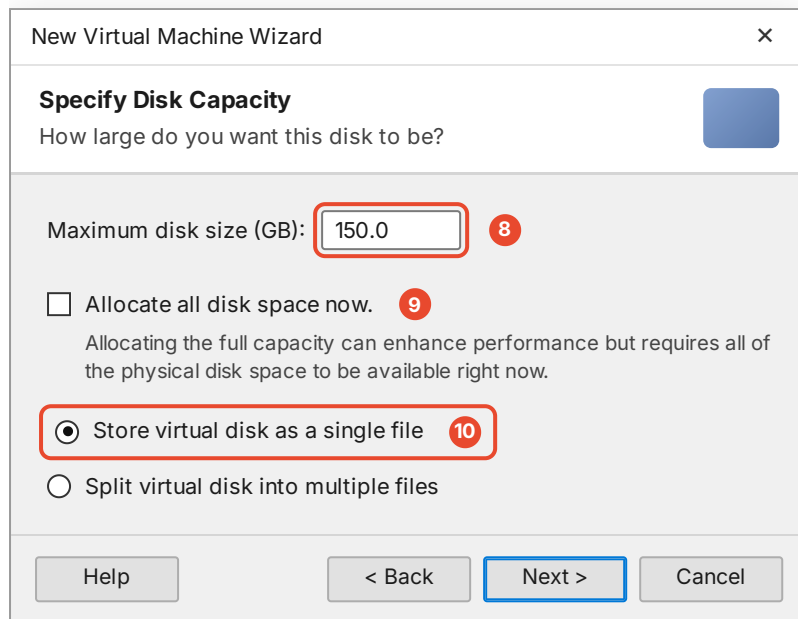
Help < Back Next > Cancel

7 With 32 GB in the PC, enter **16384 MB** (16 GB). With less than 8 GB, Xcode and the Simulator will barely work.

→ **Next: Network Type — Use network address translation (NAT); I/O Controller — keep the default.**

Fig. 14. Amount of memory.

On **Select a Disk Type**, choose **SATA**; on **Select a Disk**, choose **Create a new virtual disk**.



The screenshot shows the 'Specify Disk Capacity' step of the 'New Virtual Machine Wizard'. The title bar says 'New Virtual Machine Wizard' with a close button. The subtitle is 'Specify Disk Capacity' and the question is 'How large do you want this disk to be?'. There is a text input field for 'Maximum disk size (GB):' with the value '150.0'. Below this, there are two radio button options: 'Allocate all disk space now.' and 'Store virtual disk as a single file'. The 'Store virtual disk as a single file' option is selected. At the bottom, there are four buttons: 'Help', '< Back', 'Next >', and 'Cancel'.

Maximum disk size (GB): 150.0

☐ Allocate all disk space now.

Allocating the full capacity can enhance performance but requires all of the physical disk space to be available right now.

☒ Store virtual disk as a single file

☐ Split virtual disk into multiple files

Help < Back Next > Cancel

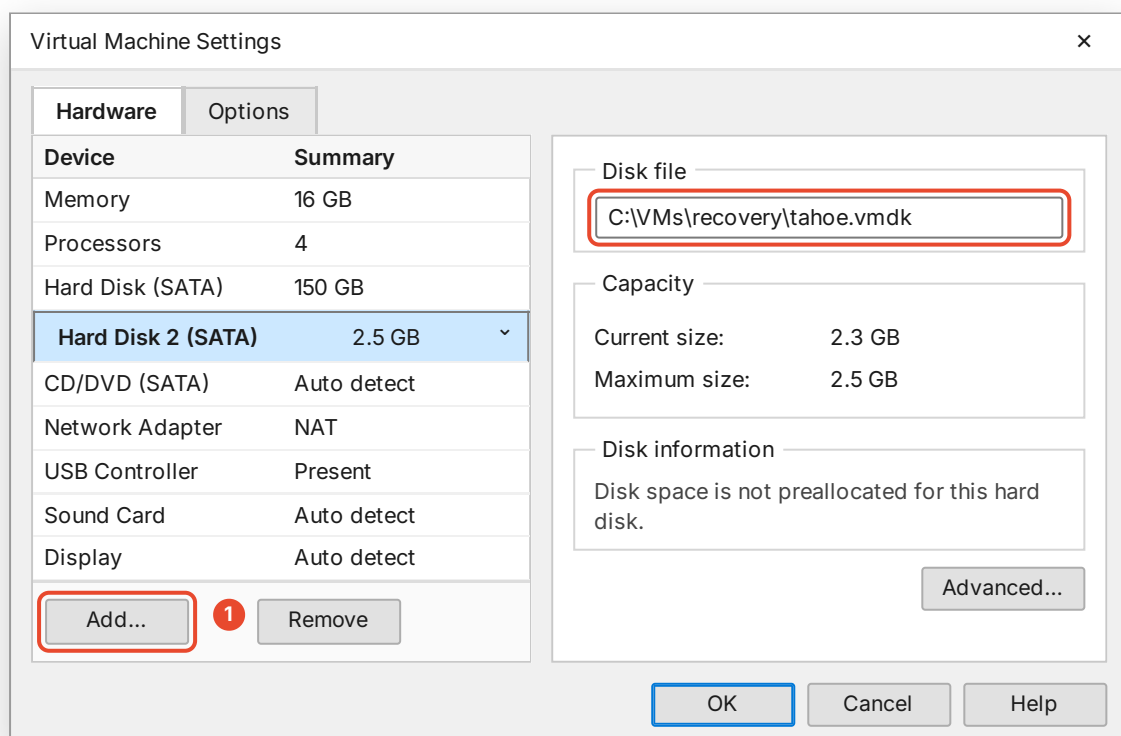
- 8 150 GB. macOS takes $\approx$ 20–25 GB, Xcode with the iOS platform another $\approx$ 25–30 GB, plus room for projects and updates.
- 9 Leave unticked — the disk will grow as it fills up.
- 10 Single file is faster.

Fig. 15. Disk size.

On **Specify Disk File**, keep the default name; on the last screen untick **Power on this virtual machine after creation** (if present) and click **Finish**.

5.2 Attach the recovery image as a second disk

1. Select the VM in the list on the left and click **Edit virtual machine settings** (or **VM → Settings...**).
2. At the bottom left, click **Add...** → select **Hard Disk** → **Next**.
3. Disk type: **SATA** → **Next**.
4. Choose **Use an existing virtual disk** → **Next** → **Browse...** and select `C:\VMs\recovery\tahoe.vmdk` → **Finish**.
5. If VMware offers to convert the disk to a newer format, click **Keep Existing Format**. A correctly built disk doesn't need converting.



The screenshot shows the 'Virtual Machine Settings' dialog with the 'Hardware' tab selected. It lists various hardware components like Memory, Processors, Hard Disk (SATA), and Hard Disk 2 (SATA). The 'Hard Disk 2 (SATA)' is highlighted, showing a capacity of 2.5 GB. On the right, the 'Disk file' field shows the path 'C:\VMs\recovery\tahoe.vmdk'. Below this, the 'Capacity' section shows 'Current size: 2.3 GB' and 'Maximum size: 2.5 GB'. The 'Disk information' section states 'Disk space is not preallocated for this hard disk.' At the bottom, there are 'Add...' and 'Remove' buttons, and 'OK', 'Cancel', and 'Help' buttons.

Device	Summary
Memory	16 GB
Processors	4
Hard Disk (SATA)	150 GB
Hard Disk 2 (SATA)	2.5 GB
CD/DVD (SATA)	Auto detect
Network Adapter	NAT
USB Controller	Present
Sound Card	Auto detect
Display	Auto detect

Hard Disk 2 (SATA) 2.5 GB

CD/DVD (SATA) Auto detect

Network Adapter NAT

USB Controller Present

Sound Card Auto detect

Display Auto detect

Add... Remove

Disk file: C:\VMs\recovery\tahoe.vmdk

Capacity

Current size: 2.3 GB

Maximum size: 2.5 GB

Disk information

Disk space is not preallocated for this hard disk.

Advanced...

OK Cancel Help

Fig. 16. Final settings: the 150 GB main disk and a second disk — the tahoe.vmdk recovery image.

5.3 Check the .vmx configuration file

Close the settings window and the powered-off VM's tab in VMware. Open `C:\VMs\macOS Tahoe`, right-click `macOS Tahoe.vmx` → **Open with** → **Notepad**. Find the lines below and make sure the values match. You don't need to add anything.

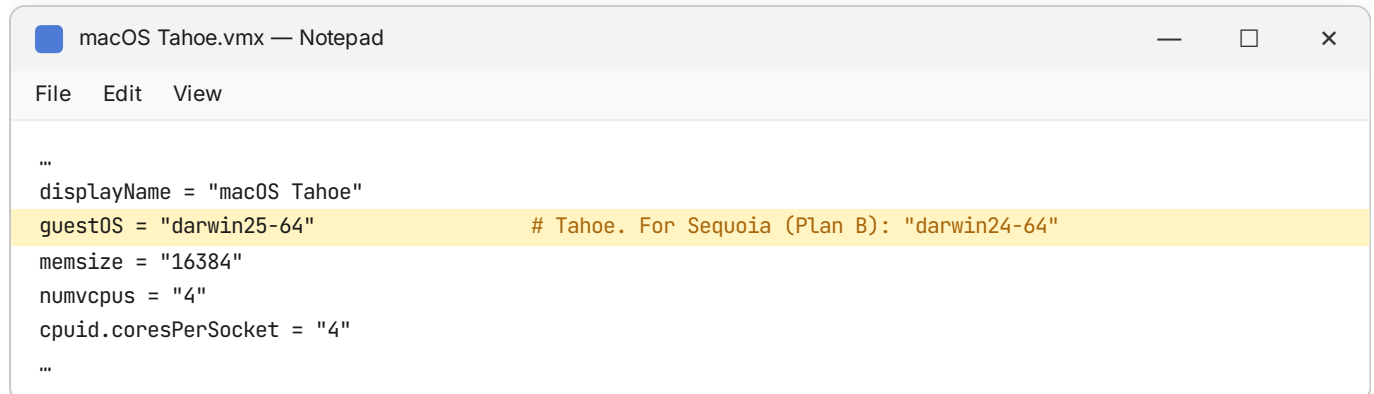


Fig. 17. Key lines of the .vmx file. guestOS must match the macOS version of the image.

If guestOS is different

Fix the value by hand, save the file (`Ctrl + S`) and only then open the VM in VMware. Edit the .vmx only while the VM is powered off, otherwise VMware overwrites your changes.

STAGE 6

Install macOS Tahoe

Installation runs over the internet: the recovery image boots, and the system itself is downloaded from Apple's servers. It takes 60–90 minutes, and the VM restarts on its own several times.

6.1 First boot

1. Click **Power on this virtual machine**. After a few seconds you should see the Apple logo with a progress bar — that means Unlocker worked.
2. If a text **Boot Manager** menu or the UEFI shell opens instead, press `Esc`, open **Boot Manager** and select the second SATA disk (**EFI VMware Virtual SATA Hard Drive** with the recovery image).
3. Choose a language (for example, **English**) and click the arrow.

The mouse barely responds in Tahoe — that's normal

Until VMware Tools are installed (Stage 7), graphics are rendered in software and the cursor lags badly in Tahoe. Use the keyboard: `Tab` moves to the next element, `Space` presses the selected button or checkbox, `Enter` activates the default (blue) button, and the arrow keys move through lists. Click once inside the window so the keyboard goes to the VM; press `Ctrl + Alt` to return the cursor to Windows.

6.2 Format the disk in Disk Utility

The macOS Recovery window will open. First choose **Disk Utility** → **Continue**.

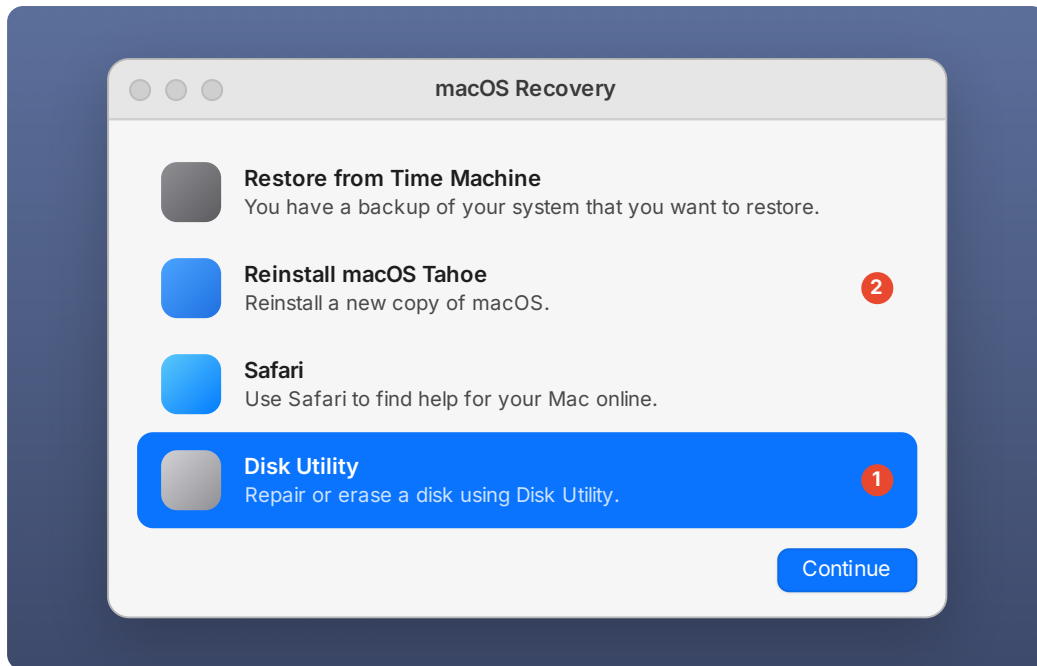


Fig. 18. The macOS Recovery window: Disk Utility first (1), then Reinstall macOS Tahoe after formatting (2).

1. In Disk Utility's menu, choose **View → Show All Devices**.
2. On the left, select the **top-level** entry of the ≈ 161 GB disk — **VMware Virtual SATA Hard Drive Media**. (macOS counts in decimal gigabytes, so VMware's 150 GB shows as ≈ 161 GB.) Don't pick the ≈ 2.7 GB disk — that's the recovery image.
3. Click **Erase** and fill in the fields as in the figure below → **Erase → Done**.
4. Quit Disk Utility (`Win + Q` , which is `⌘Q` in macOS) — you'll return to the Recovery window.

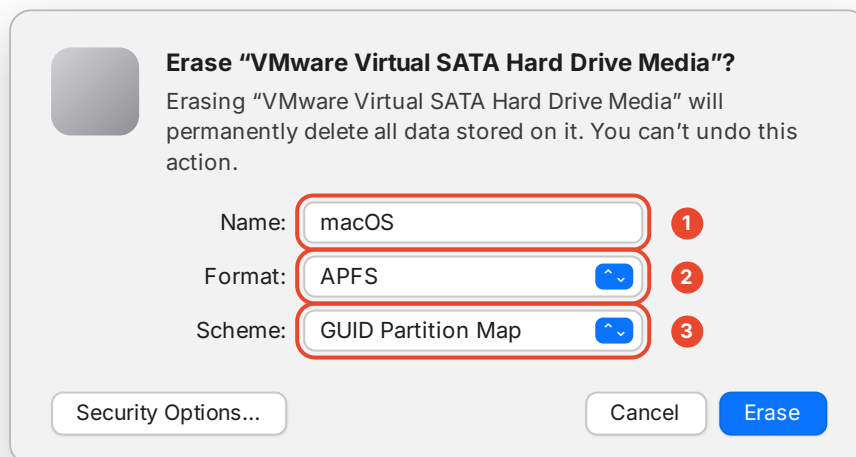


Fig. 19. Erase settings: name "macOS", format APFS, scheme GUID Partition Map.

6.3 Start the installation

1. In the Recovery window, choose **Reinstall macOS Tahoe → Continue → Continue** again.
2. Accept the license agreement: **Agree → Agree**.
3. Select the **macOS** disk (the one you just created) → **Continue**.
4. Wait. At first the timer may show 2 hours or more — it recalculates later. The actual install takes 40–60 minutes. The VM will restart 2–3 times — don't touch anything.

6.4 Initial setup (Setup Assistant)

After installation, Setup Assistant opens. Go through the screens using this table — the highlighted items matter most.

Screen	What to choose
Select Your Country or Region	Your country → Continue
Languages, Accessibility, Data & Privacy	Continue / Not Now
Migration Assistant	Not Now
Sign In with Your Apple Account	Set Up Later → Skip. Signing in to an Apple Account doesn't work in a VM — don't waste time on it.
Terms and Conditions	Agree
Create a Mac Account	Full name, an account name in Latin letters without spaces, and a password . Remember the password — you'll need it to install VMware Tools and for <code>sudo</code> commands.
Enable Location Services	Untick → Don't Use
Select Your Time Zone	Pick it on the map manually
Analytics	Untick "Share Mac Analytics with Apple"
Screen Time, Siri	Set Up Later / turn off
FileVault	Don't turn it on. Disk encryption noticeably slows down a VM.
Updates	Only Download Automatically , so the system doesn't update itself without you knowing.
Choose Your Look	Any → Continue

When the macOS desktop appears, installation is complete. Shut the VM down: Apple menu → **Shut Down**.

STAGE 7

After installation: VMware Tools and speed-ups

VMware Tools are the drivers for macOS: without them the screen resolution doesn't change, the shared clipboard doesn't work, and in Tahoe the mouse lags too.

7.1 Detach the recovery image

With the VM powered off, open **VM → Settings**, select **Hard Disk 2 (SATA)** (2.5 GB) → **Remove** → **OK**. The `tahoe.vmdk` file itself isn't deleted from the disk — you can keep it in case you need to reinstall.

7.2 Install VMware Tools

1. Power on the VM and log in to macOS. In VMware's menu, choose **VM → Install VMware Tools...** — a **VMware Tools** disk will mount in macOS.
2. Open it in Finder and run **Install VMware Tools** → **Continue** → **Install** → enter your account password.
3. A **"System Extension Blocked"** message will appear. Click **Open Security Settings**.

4. In **Privacy & Security**, scroll down and click **Allow** next to the message about VMware, Inc. — see the figure below. Enter your password.
5. Wait for the installation to finish (updating the boot volume takes longer than the progress bar suggests) and click **Restart**.

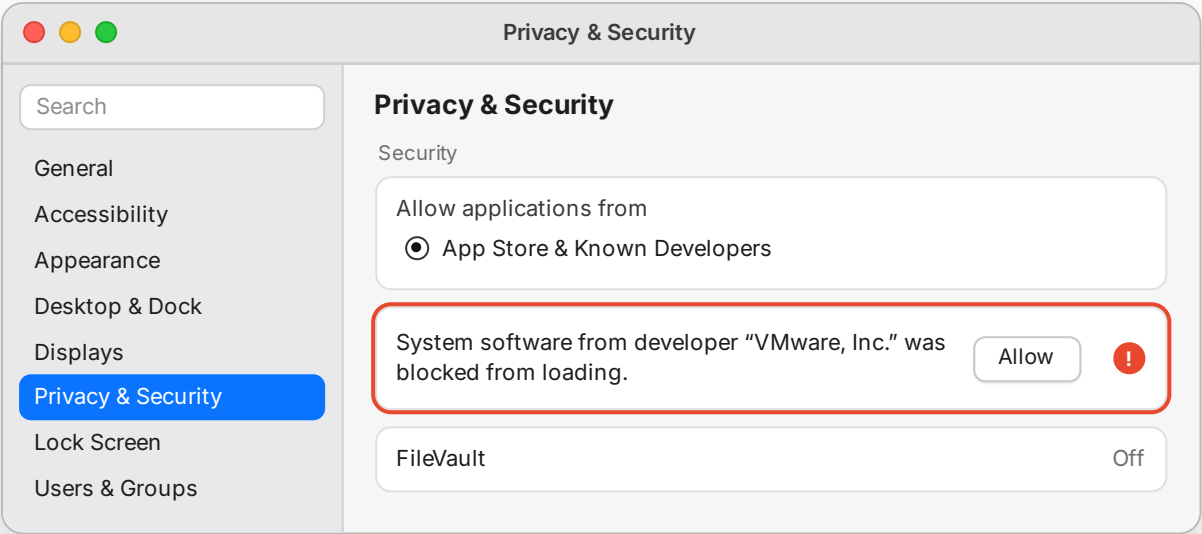


Fig. 20. System Settings → Privacy & Security. You must click Allow — otherwise Tools install but don't work. In some versions the text reads "Some system software requires your attention"; in that case click "Details..."

How to tell Tools are working

After the restart, the macOS resolution follows the size of the VMware window, the cursor moves smoothly, and VMware's **VM → Install VMware Tools...** menu item changes to **Reinstall VMware Tools....** If macOS asks for Accessibility permission for VMware components, allow it in the same settings section.

If "Install VMware Tools" is greyed out

Attach the image manually: **VM → Settings → CD/DVD (SATA) → Use ISO image file →** `C:\Program Files\VMware\VMware Workstation\darwin.iso`, tick **Connected** → **OK**. Unlocker downloaded this file in Stage 3.

7.3 Speed up the interface

Where (System Settings)	What to do
Accessibility → Display	Turn on "Reduce motion" and "Reduce transparency"
Lock Screen	"Turn display off when inactive" → Never
Apple Intelligence & Siri	Turn off
Desktop & Dock	Turn off effects and Dock auto-hide
Privacy & Security → Analytics	Turn everything off

7.4 Keyboard and file transfer

Key on the PC	In macOS
Win	⌘ Command. Copy — Win + C, paste — Win + V, close window — Win + W, quit app — Win + Q

Alt

⌘ Option

Ctrl + Alt

Release the mouse and keyboard back to Windows

Shared folder with Windows (optional). Shut the VM down → **VM** → **Settings** → **Options** → **Shared Folders** → **Always enabled** → **Add...** and pick a folder on the PC. In macOS it appears at `/Volumes/VMware Shared Folders/<name>` (in Finder: **Go** → **Go to Folder**, `Win + Shift + G`). Shared folders occasionally crash macOS; if that happens, simply drag files from Windows into the macOS window instead.

Take a snapshot — it will save you hours

Shut macOS down and choose **VM** → **Snapshot** → **Take Snapshot...**, and name it, for example, "Clean Tahoe + Tools". If something breaks later, you can return to this state in a minute via **VM** → **Snapshot** → **Revert to Snapshot** instead of reinstalling the system.

STAGE 8

Xcode 26.6 and the iOS 26.5 Simulator

The final stage: download the Intel-compatible build of Xcode, add the iOS 26.5 platform and launch an iPhone.

8.1 Download Xcode 26.6 (Universal build)

1. In macOS, open Safari and go to developer.apple.com/download/all. Sign in with your Apple Account (a free account is enough; on first sign-in the site asks you to accept the Apple Developer Agreement). Signing in on the website works inside the VM — only signing in to the system itself doesn't.
2. Search for **Xcode 26.6** and expand the result.
3. Download the **Universal** file (≈ 3 GB). The file marked **Apple silicon won't work** — it runs only on Macs with M-series chips.



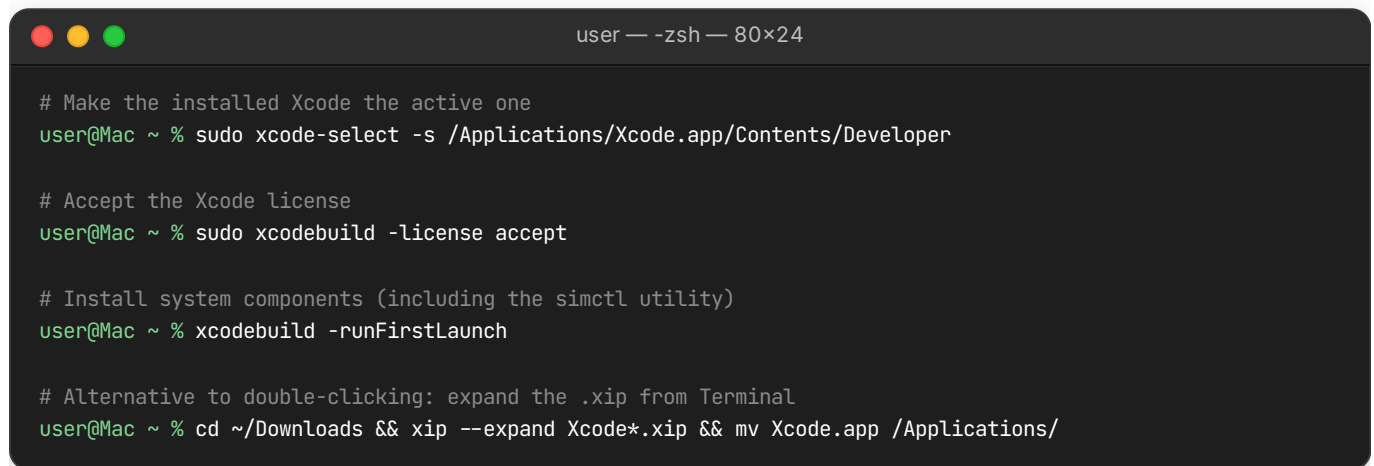
Fig. 21. The Apple Developer downloads page (schematic). Exact file names may differ — what matters is that the name does not include "Apple silicon".

Faster option

You can also download the file in a browser on Windows and then drag it into the macOS window (into Downloads) or put it in the shared folder from step 7.4. A Windows browser is faster than Safari inside the VM.

8.2 Install Xcode

1. Double-click the `.xip` file in Downloads — Archive Utility will expand it (10–30 minutes; you need about 3× the file size in free space while it expands).
2. Drag the resulting **Xcode.app** into the **Applications** folder.
3. Open **Terminal** (Win + Space → "Terminal") and run the commands below. For `sudo`, the system asks for your account password — it isn't shown as you type, which is normal.



```
user — -zsh — 80x24

# Make the installed Xcode the active one
user@Mac ~ % sudo xcode-select -s /Applications/Xcode.app/Contents/Developer

# Accept the Xcode license
user@Mac ~ % sudo xcodebuild -license accept

# Install system components (including the simctl utility)
user@Mac ~ % xcodebuild -runFirstLaunch

# Alternative to double-clicking: expand the .xip from Terminal
user@Mac ~ % cd ~/Downloads && xip --expand Xcode*.xip && mv Xcode.app /Applications/
```

Fig. 22. Initial Xcode setup in the macOS Terminal.

8.3 Add the iOS 26.5 platform

On first launch, Xcode shows a platform selection window. Tick **iOS** and click **Download & Install**. About 8–10 GB will be downloaded. On Intel machines Xcode picks the right (universal) variant by itself — you don't need to change anything.

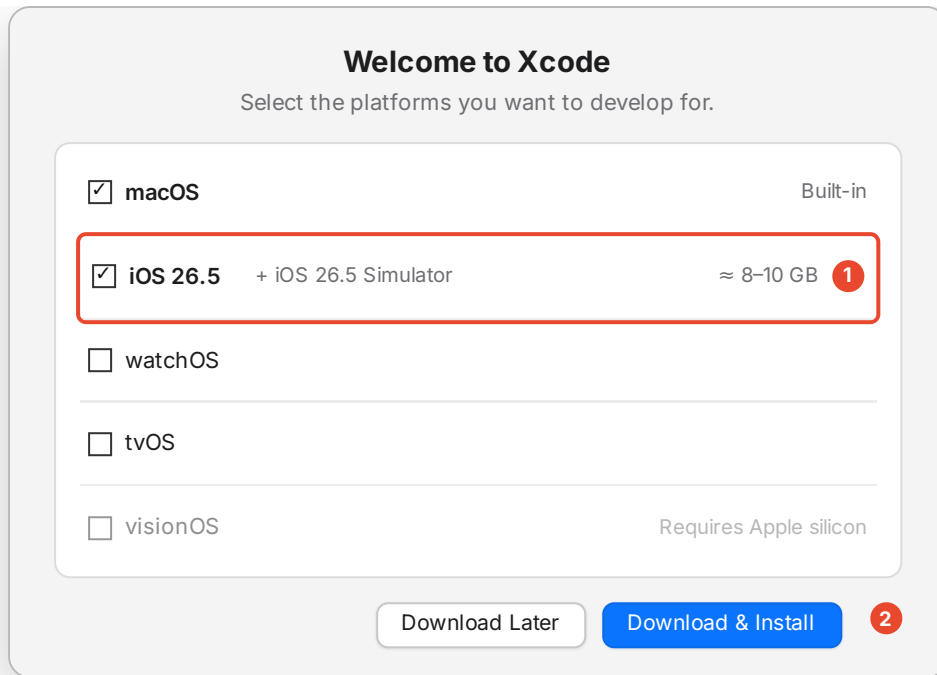


Fig. 23. Xcode's first-launch window (schematic). If you skipped it, open Xcode → Settings → Components and click Get next to iOS 26.5.

If the download from Xcode's window stalls or fails, download the platform from Terminal and check that it installed:

```
user — -zsh — 80x24

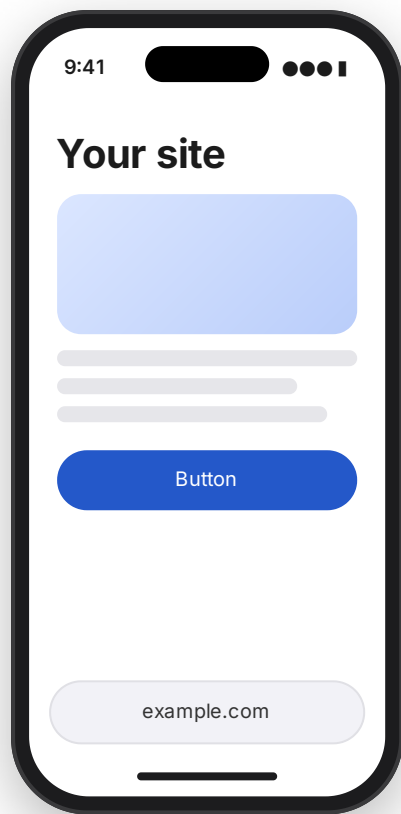
# Download and install the latest iOS platform for the current Xcode
user@Mac ~ % xcodebuild -downloadPlatform iOS

# Check the installed simulator runtimes
user@Mac ~ % xcrun simctl list runtimes
= Runtimes =
iOS 26.5 (26.5 - ...) - com.apple.CoreSimulator.SimRuntime.iOS-26-5

# Offline option: a platform .dmg downloaded from developer.apple.com (Universal variant)
user@Mac ~ % xcodebuild -importPlatform ~/Downloads/iOS_26.5_Simulator_Runtime.dmg
```

Fig. 24. Installing and checking the iOS platform from Terminal. Use your own .dmg file name.

8.4 Launch the iPhone Simulator



- 1. In Xcode, choose **Xcode** → **Open Developer Tool** → **Simulator**. Or press `Win + Space` and type "Simulator".
- 2. In Simulator: **File** → **Open Simulator** → **iOS 26.5** → **iPhone 17 Pro** (or any other model in the list).
- 3. The first iPhone boot takes 1–3 minutes. After that it's faster.
- 4. Open Safari inside the Simulator and enter a website address.

Fig. 25. The iPhone Simulator with iOS 26.5 (illustrative).

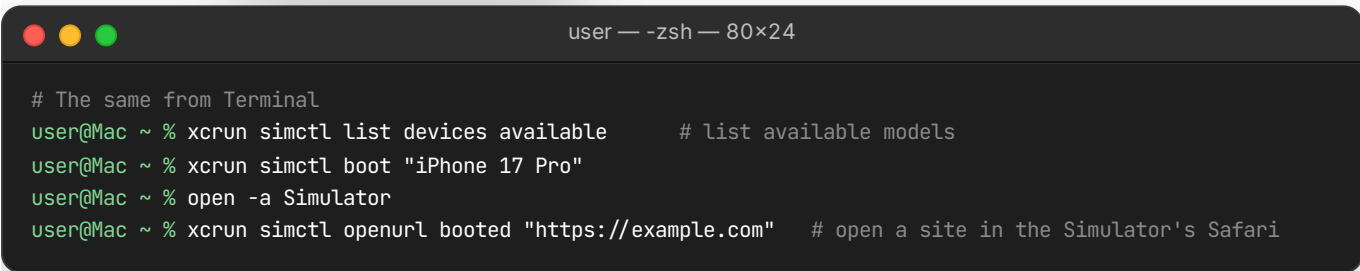


Fig. 26. Controlling the Simulator from Terminal.

8.5 What you can do in the Simulator

Task	How
Test a site in mobile Safari	Open Safari in the Simulator or run <code>xcrun simctl openurl booted "https://..."</code> .
Debug layout and JavaScript	In Safari on macOS: Settings → Advanced → turn on "Show features for web developers". In the Develop menu, choose Simulator — iPhone 17 Pro → your page, and Web Inspector opens.
Open a site running on Windows	Instead of <code>localhost</code> , use the IP address of the VMware Network Adapter VMnet8 from <code>ipconfig</code> on Windows. The server must listen on <code>0.0.0.0</code> , and the port must be allowed in Windows Firewall.
Run your own app	Open the project in Xcode, choose the iPhone 17 Pro device at the top and click the ► Run button.
Install a ready Simulator build	Drag <code>MyApp.app</code> onto the Simulator window or run <code>xcrun simctl install booted MyApp.app</code> . Only Simulator builds work; <code>.ipa</code> files for real devices don't.

Simulator action	Shortcut on the PC	Menu
Home	Win + Shift + H	Device → Home
Rotate the screen	Win + ← / Win + →	Device → Rotate Left / Right
Screenshot	Win + S	File → Save Screen (saved to the macOS desktop)
Location	—	Features → Location → Custom Location...

Windows may intercept some shortcuts with the `Win` key. If that happens, use the Simulator's menus or install VMware's Enhanced Keyboard Driver (step 2.2).

TROUBLESHOOTING

If something goes wrong

Problem	Solution
VMware says VT-x isn't available, or the VM won't power on	Enable Intel VT-x in BIOS (step 1.1) and turn off Hyper-V (steps 1.2–1.4).
Everything is very slow, and <code>vmware.log</code> (in the VM folder) shows <code>ULM</code> as the monitor mode	VMware is running on top of Hyper-V. Repeat steps 1.2–1.4 and check <code>msinfo32</code> . Once fixed, the log should show <code>CPL0</code> mode.
No Apple logo: black screen, a reboot loop, or "The CPU has been disabled by the guest operating system"	Check three things: Unlocker is applied (after a VMware update, run <code>win-install.cmd</code> again); <code>guestOS</code> in the <code>.vmx</code> matches the image (step 5.3); the VM is set to 1 processor × 4 cores.
VMware crashes when starting the VM, and the log says "Third party host clock rate has already been set"	Add the line <code>mks.enableVulkanPresentation = "FALSE"</code> to the <code>.vmx</code> . This is a known bug in version 25H2, fixed in 25H2u1.
The installer doesn't see the mouse or keyboard	Shut the VM down: VM → Settings → USB Controller → switch USB compatibility from USB 3.1 to USB 2.0 (or the other way round).
The installer crashes or restarts midway	Temporarily lower memory to 8192 MB; after installation set it back to 16384 MB.
The installer doesn't see the disk	Disk Utility → View → Show All Devices → erase the top-level disk entry as APFS / GUID (step 6.2).
Tools are installed, but the resolution doesn't change and the mouse lags	You haven't clicked Allow in Privacy & Security. Click it and restart macOS (step 7.2).
Xcode says it requires macOS 26.2 or later	System Settings → General → Software Update → install the latest Tahoe 26.x. Or use Xcode 26.3, which only needs Sequoia 15.6.
Xcode won't open: "not supported on this Mac"	You downloaded the Apple silicon build. Download the Universal one (step 8.1).
The iOS platform won't download from Xcode	<code>xcodebuild -downloadPlatform iOS</code> in Terminal, or install the <code>.dmg</code> manually (step 8.3).

Unlocker doesn't work with your VMware version

An alternative is **OC4VM** (github.com/DrDonk/OC4VM): ready-made VM templates with the OpenCore bootloader, no VMware patching needed. Officially tested on Workstation 17.6 and 25H2.

Plan B: macOS Sequoia instead of Tahoe

The OC4VM author states plainly that Tahoe isn't recommended as a virtual machine yet, and suggests Sonoma or Sequoia. If Tahoe is unstable for you, go through the guide again with three changes:

1. **Stage 4:** in recoveryOS choose **6 — Sequoia** (file `sequoia.vmdk`). For the manual method use `-board-id Mac-937A206F2EE63C01 -basename sequoia`.
2. **Stage 5:** guest version **macOS 15**, and in the .vmx `guestOS = "darwin24-64"`.
3. **Stage 8:** first update Sequoia to the latest 15.x (15.6 or later is required), then download **Xcode 26.3** (Universal). The Simulator will be **iOS 26.2**.

How to restore Windows to its original state

If you no longer need the VM and want to use WSL 2, Docker Desktop or Windows Sandbox again, run the following in PowerShell as administrator and restart:

```
Administrator: Windows PowerShell
PS C:\Windows\system32> bcdedit /set hypervisorlaunchtype auto
PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Enable-Feature:VirtualMachinePlatform /All /NoRestart
PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Enable-Feature:HypervisorPlatform /All /NoRestart
PS C:\Windows\system32> dism.exe /Online /Enable-Feature:Microsoft-Hyper-V-All /All /NoRestart # Pro/Enter
prise only
```

Turn Memory integrity back on in the same place you turned it off (step 1.2). The VMware patch is rolled back with the uninstall script in the Unlocker folder (`win-uninstall.cmd`, if the archive includes it) or by reinstalling VMware.

Checklist

- ☐ Windows: VT-x enabled, Hyper-V and Memory integrity off
- ☐ VMware Workstation 26H1 installed, automatic updates off
- ☐ Unlocker 3.1.4 applied, Apple Mac OS X shows up in the list of systems
- ☐ You have `tahoe.vmdk` ($\approx$ 2.3 GB)
- ☐ VM: macOS 26, 1 × 4 cores, 16 GB, 150 GB SATA disk + second disk `tahoe.vmdk`
- ☐ macOS installed, Apple Account skipped, FileVault off
- ☐ Second disk removed, VMware Tools installed and allowed, snapshot taken
- ☐ Xcode 26.6 Universal in Applications, license accepted
- ☐ iOS 26.5 platform installed, iPhone 17 Pro launches

Sources

This guide is based on official Apple and Broadcom documentation and on community guides tested on VMware Workstation 26H1 and Windows 11 in 2026. Software versions and interfaces change — if something doesn't match the text, go by the current pages below.

1. Apple — Xcode system requirements: developer.apple.com/xcode/system-requirements

2. Apple — Downloading and installing additional Xcode components: developer.apple.com/documentation/xcode/downloading-and-installing-additional-xcode-components
3. Xcode version history (minimum macOS, SDKs, Intel support): mungomash.com/software/xcode/versions
4. Broadcom KB 368734 — Download Desktop Hypervisor (Workstation and Fusion) products: knowledge.broadcom.com/external/article/368734
5. VMware Workstation Pro 26H1 Release Notes: techdocs.broadcom.com (Desktop Hypervisors → Workstation Pro → 26 H1)
6. macOS on VMware Workstation 26.x — full chain tested on 26H1: github.com/aesiddiqui/macos-on-vmware-workstation
7. BDisp/unlocker (version 3.1.4 for Workstation 26.x): github.com/BDisp/unlocker
8. DrDonk/recoveryOS — downloading macOS recovery images: github.com/DrDonk/recoveryOS
9. DrDonk/OC4VM — wiki, Tahoe Limitations and Knowledge Base: github.com/DrDonk/OC4VM/wiki
10. VideoCardz — Apple drops Intel Mac support with macOS 27, Tahoe 26 is the final release: videocardz.com
11. 9to5Mac — separate Xcode 26 build for Apple silicon: 9to5mac.com/2025/08/05